

THE LIGHT PAINTING METHOD

A Complete Guide To Light Painting
By Mitch Hemming



Light painting is the technique that changed everything for my photography.

It is what allowed my work to stand out and get noticed by major automotive brands.

My name is **Mitch Hemming**. I am an automotive photographer and the founder of Consistent Creative & Aventus Media.



I have spent the last 15 years photographing hundreds of cars using light painting. Through that time, I have refined the process into something repeatable and reliable. Not guesswork.

This guide is about showing you the fastest way to learn the technique properly and apply it with confidence.

We are in a world where almost everyone has a camera. Standing out is no longer optional.

Most automotive photographers rely on natural light and heavy editing to carry the image. Very few truly understand how to use artificial light.

That gap is your opportunity.

There has never been a better time to learn light painting and use it as a genuine advantage.

Let's get into it.

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What Gear Do You Need?

This is one of the biggest misconceptions around light painting.

You do not need expensive or complicated gear to get started.

If your goal is to work professionally, there is a minimum level of camera body I would recommend. But it's not a deal breaker.

I started with an entry level crop sensor 12 megapixel camera. It worked. But I outgrew it quickly. My lighting and editing improved faster than the files I could produce.

The limitation was no longer my technique. It was the camera. So if you want to turn this into paid work, plan to step things up over time.

CAMERA

Stick to main brands Sony, Nikon, Canon

- Full Frame Mirrorless camera body
- 24-70mm or similar range zoom (Same brand as your camera body)
- Cable or remote shutter release (Options vary per camera)

TRIPOD

DO NOT skimp out on this.

Long exposure results are as good as your tripod.

- Manfrotto or preferred high quality tripod. Get a bigger weight rating tripod than you think you need. Stability is everything with long exposure at night.

LED LIGHT

- You can use ANY brand with the following ideal requirements
 - o Handheld and not too heavy
 - o Rechargeable
 - o Pure white (4000k-5000k) or adjustable temperature
 - o Single sided light output (Not a 360 degree tube) so you can aim it
 - o Tip: Automotive workshop style lights are most robust. They generally have a rubber outer covering and provide large battery life (The ones you would find in a mechanic workshop)

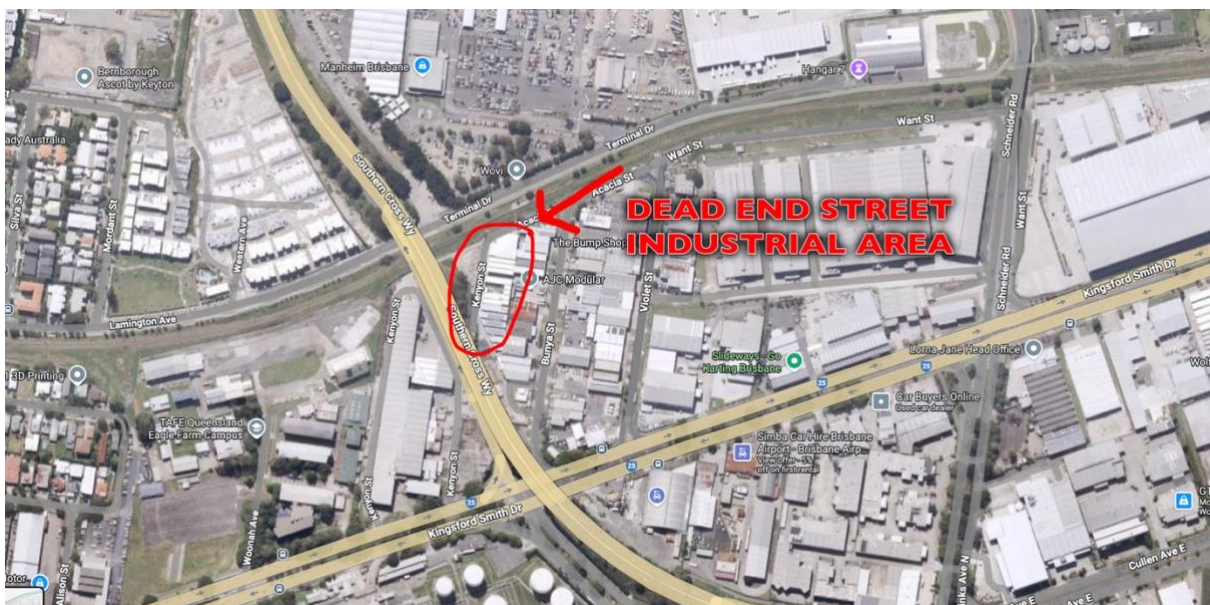
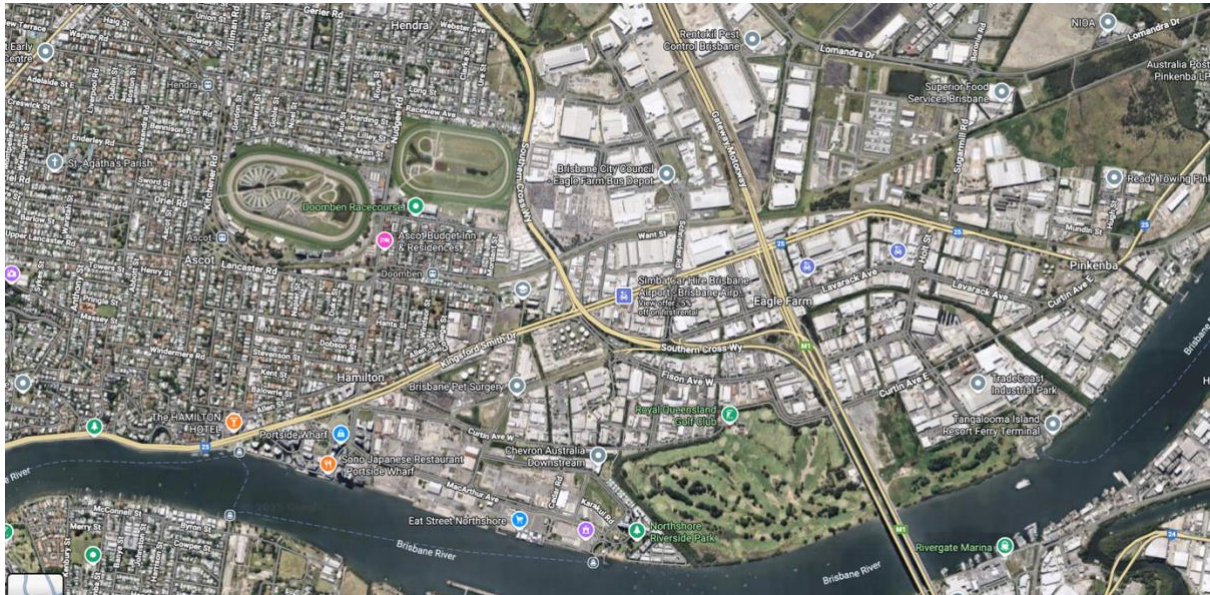
Finding The Right Locations

Locations for light painting require research and experience.

You need to understand how light or dark an area is at night, what environmental factors come into play, and how you want the final image to look.

If you want a completely dark background with full control over ambient light, a private building or warehouse is ideal. Somewhere you can turn all lights off manually. This is not always possible.

For most shoots, I use a very simple method. *Google Maps and Street View.*



I search the area in Google Maps. When something looks promising, I switch to Street View and move through it as if I am there in person. I look for dead end streets, industrial backgrounds, river/city views etc.



I will often spend hours doing this in preparation for a shoot.

Once I have two or three locations shortlisted, I visit them in person at the exact time and day I plan to shoot. For example, Monday at 8pm.

This reveals the make or break details of a location. Once something is locked in, you know there will be no surprises on the night.

The worst case scenario is being asked to leave a location without a backup already planned. **So make sure you always have a 2nd location nearby.**



Camera Setup Checklist

I like to get to the location before the car has arrived. This gives me time to plan out each composition and get my gear setup. Or if the location is a bust, you can switch to plan b location, notify your client and meet them there instead.

I've made a setup checklist below to keep things simple:

- Plan your composition. Where the car will sit and on what angle.
- Setup tripod at ideal height.
- Setup camera basics (Clean lens, memory card, full battery, cable/remote release).
- Once your camera is on tripod, setup ideal composition/framing.
- Focus on the car, shoot a test image. Make sure the framing looks good.
- Setup your manual camera settings. Here's a rough starting point. Adjust as needed.
- ISO 100-500, Aperture f4-f6, Shutter speed 4s – 10s.
- Shoot another test photo with desired settings, tweak ISO/f stop where needed.
- Grab LED light, shoot test photo lighting up any part of the car. Check exposure/focus.
- Once everything is looking good, start shooting! Lighting up the car. Check each time.

*NOTES: I do not recommend using a polariser or ND filter when light painting.
Triple check your focus point. Make sure your tripod is locked and stable.*

Light Painting Techniques

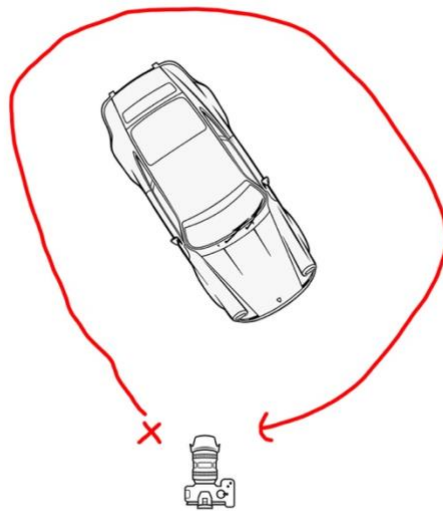
*Technique is everything. This is where light painting really comes together.
Below are the main ways I approach lighting a car.*

Lighting The Car In A Single Exposure

This involves using a longer shutter speed, usually ten seconds or more and lighting the entire car in one exposure.

This works best in very dark environments where you have minimal ambient light to deal with.

It is simple, but it leaves very little room for correction.



Lighting The Car Using Multiple Exposures

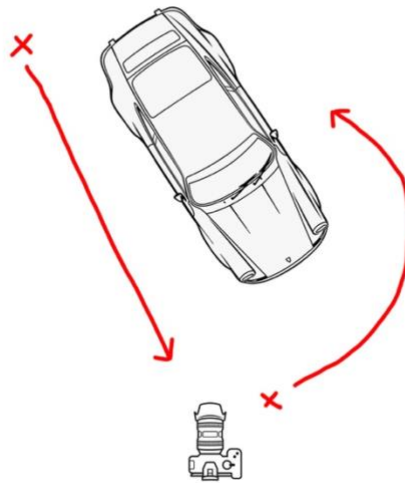
This is where you break the car into sections and light each part individually.

For example, the front, the side, the wheels and the interior.

This can be as simple as two images, such as a front pass and a side pass. It can also become more complex, using ten or more images to light every section independently.

I recommend starting with two exposures and building from there as your confidence grows.

This method offers far more control and consistency.



Holding The Light High Vs Low

The position of your light has a huge impact on the final result.

Holding your light higher will introduce more contrast and deeper shadows. This works well when you want shape and definition.

Holding the light lower produces a more direct and even light. This can work well on cars with deep metallic paint finishes.

The best approach is to test different heights and angles. Small changes make a big difference.



Balancing Ambient Light With Your LED Light

You can choose to add a subtle amount of light or completely overpower the ambient light. This depends on your camera settings and your intent.

During your initial setup, your base image will show you how bright or dark the scene is. This becomes your reference.

Adjust your LED output to suit. If your light does not have power adjustment, your distance from the car will control how strong or weak the light appears.

Bonus: Lighting Tricks For Black/Dark Coloured Cars

Black or very dark coloured cars are often talked about as the hardest cars to shoot.

The reality is they just need a different approach.

Think of a black car like a glass mirror. Whatever is around is exactly what you are going to see reflected.

If you put a black car in a busy environment with lots of ambient light, other cars, or distractions, all of that will show up in the paint.

If you put that same car in a dark, controlled environment, the result changes completely. You decide what gets reflected into the car.

This is why a lot of pre digital and pre Photoshop automotive images were shot at sunset in wide open spaces. There was nothing ugly to reflect. Take the same approach.

To shoot black cars well, you need to control the environment first.

The better the result you get in camera, the better photographer you become. The mindset of fixing everything later in Photoshop leads to bad habits.

The only real way to get good at shooting black cars is to stop avoiding them and practice.. a lot!



Editing In Photoshop

This process scales with your skill level and the number of lighting layers you use. When starting out, keep it simple.

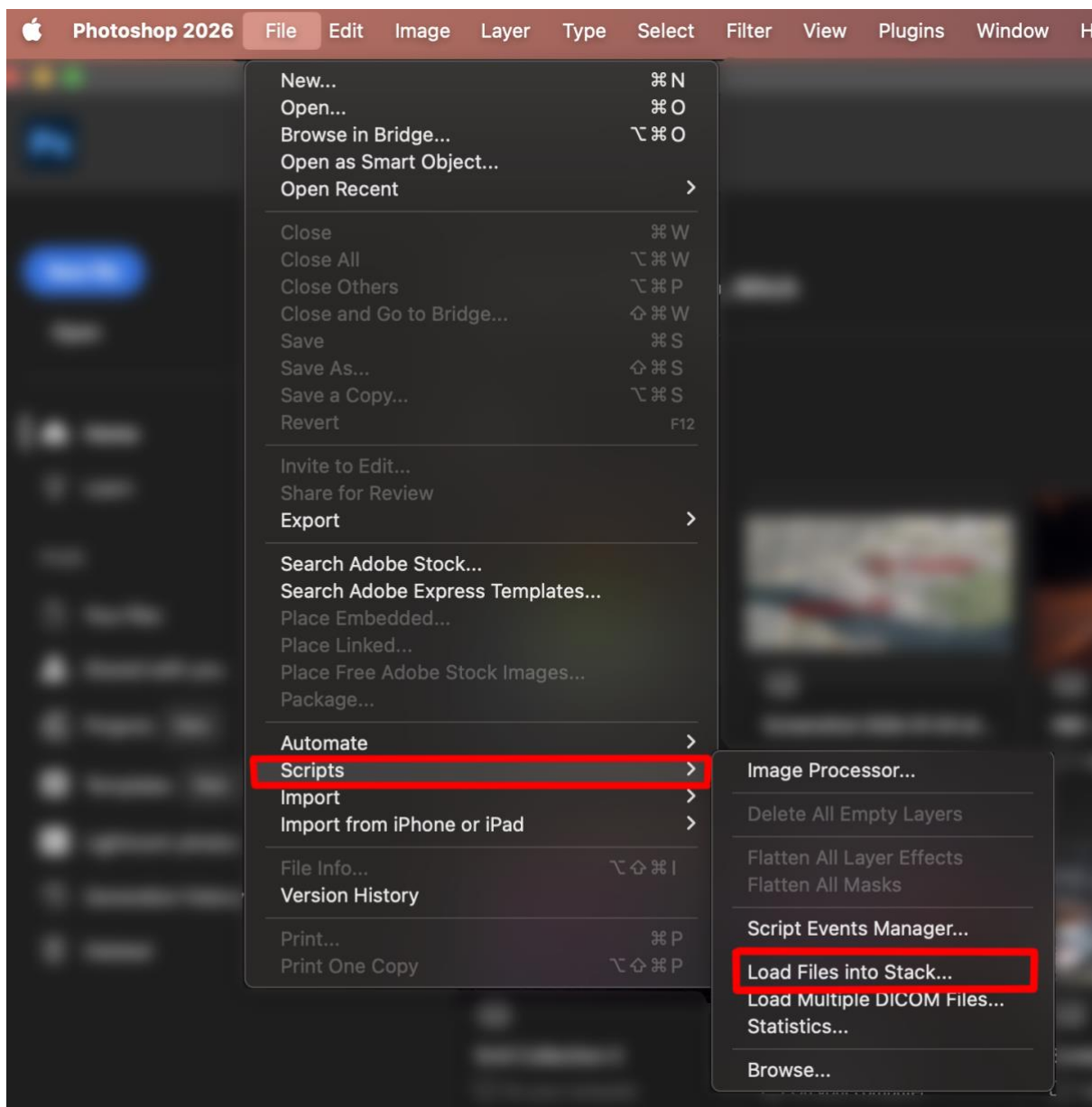
RAW Photos In Lightroom

Before you can load your photos into Photoshop, you will first need to convert them from RAW to JPG format.

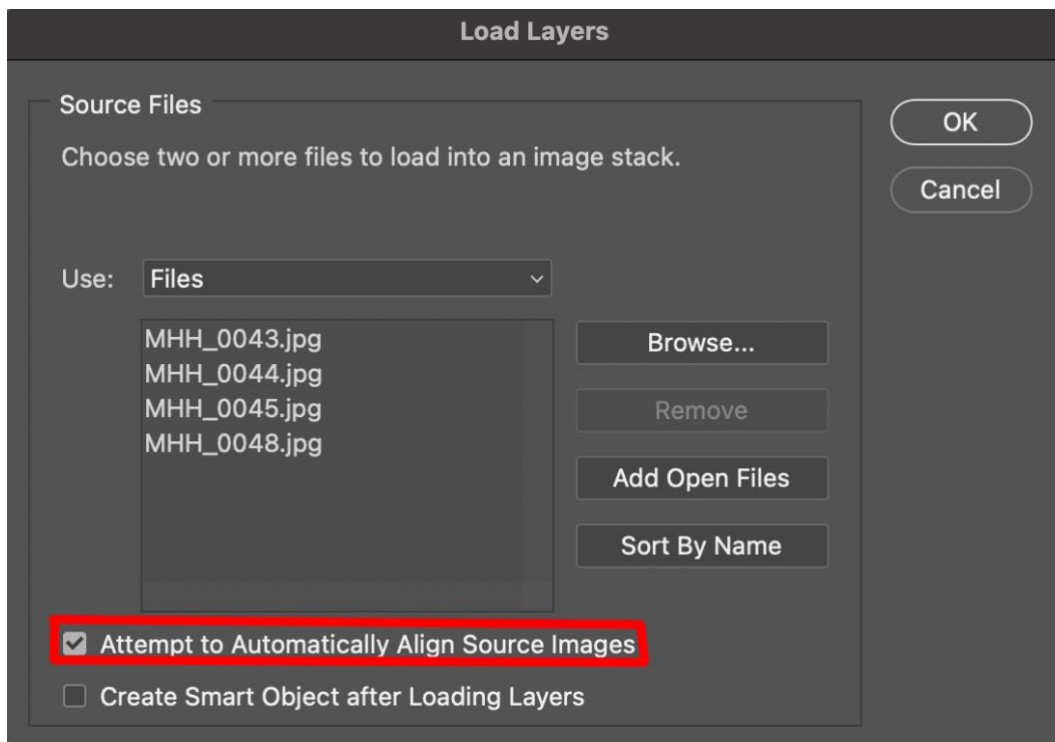
Make sure you correct your white balance for all chosen images in LR before you export and load into PS.

Loading Photos In As Layers

File -> Scripts -> Load Files Into Stack -> Select all of your chosen JPG images you exported from Lightroom

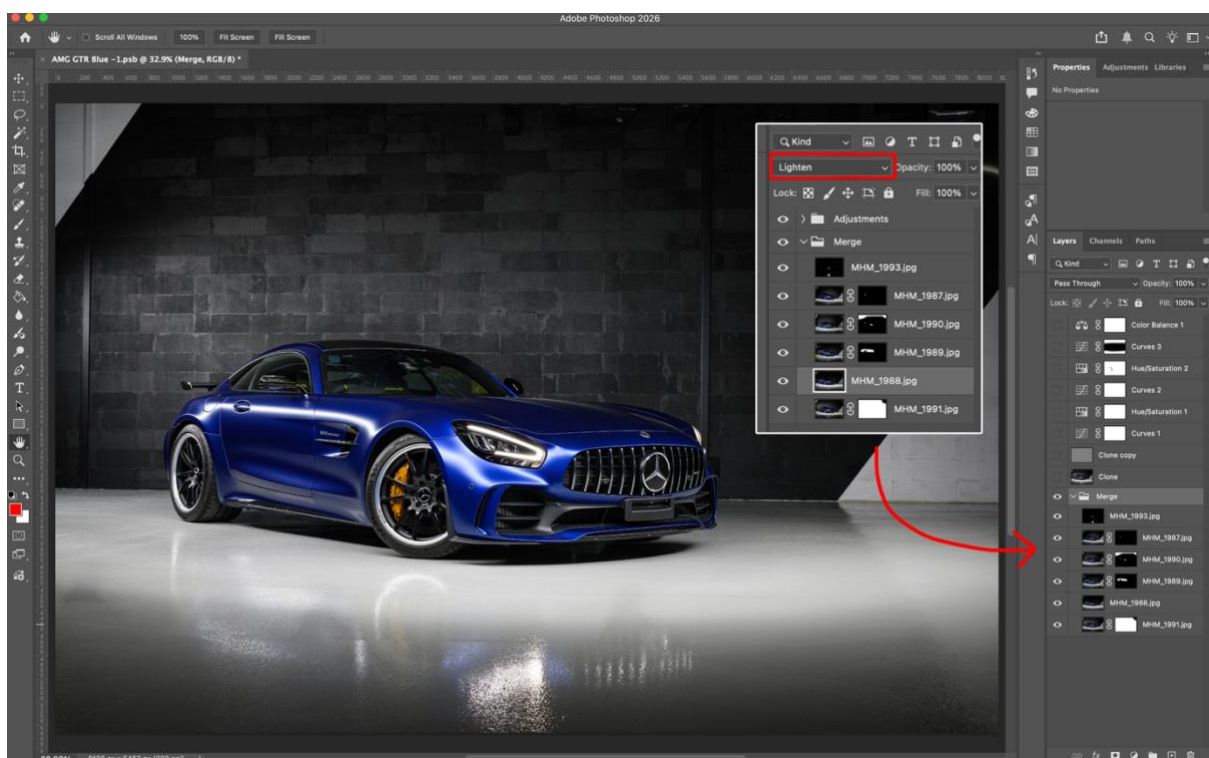


Make sure to tick the Automatic Align checkbox

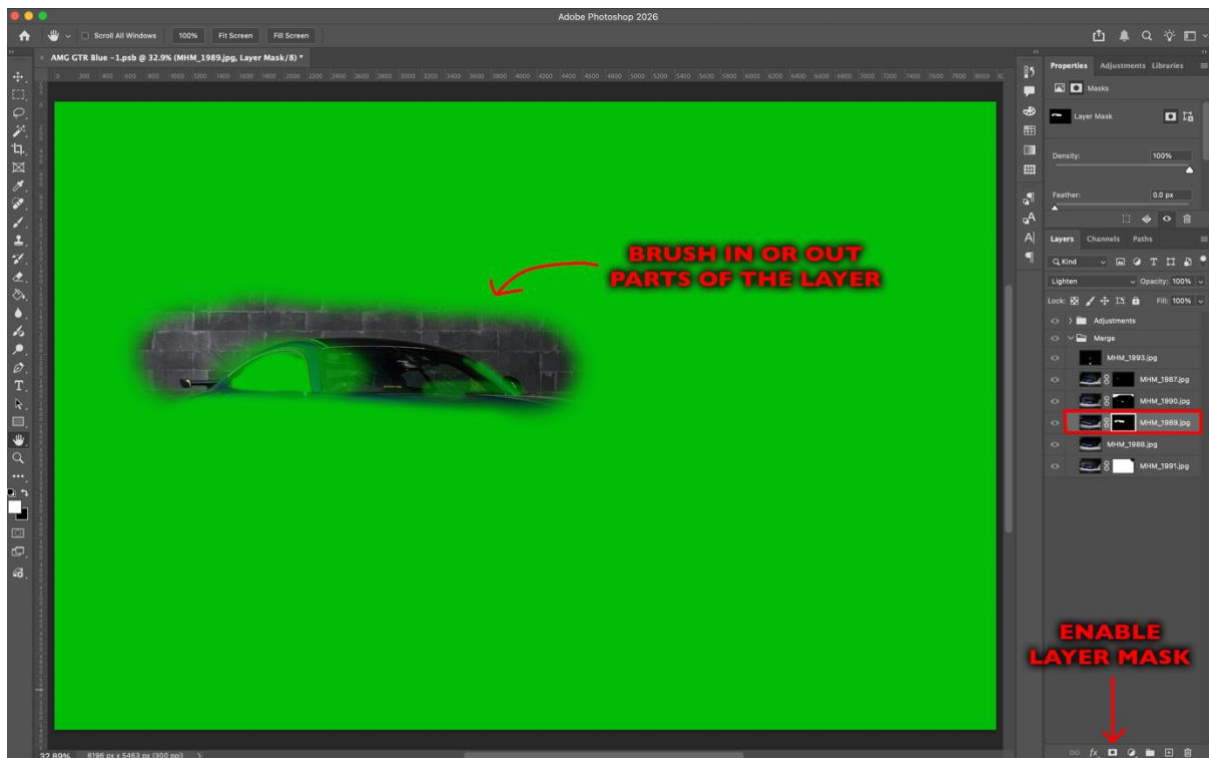


Using Blend Modes And Layer Masks

Once layers are stacked, change their blend mode to **Lighten**. This will add the lighting from each layer.

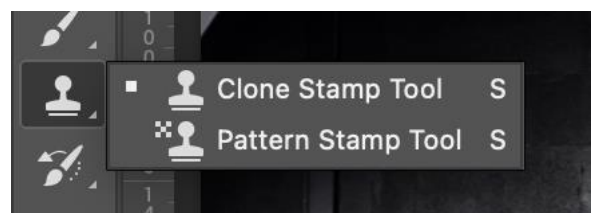
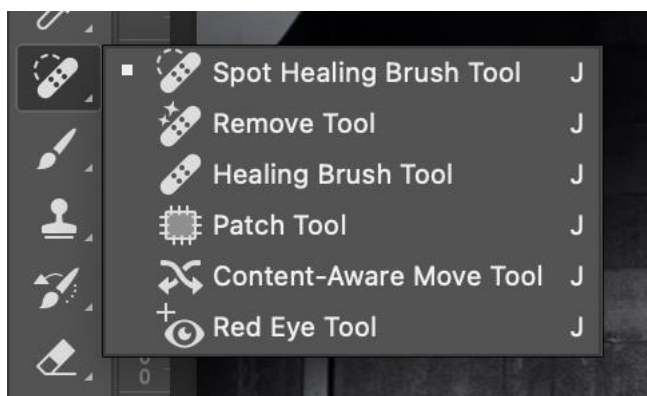


If you want to be more selective with which parts of each photo is used, enable **layer masks** and then brush in (or out) parts of the photo you want. (The green shown below is the part that is *not* being revealed)



Cleaning Up Distractions & Colour Grading

Using various clone tools, clean up any distractions in the image. Reflections on the car, background objects etc.



I use a combination of Curves layers, HUE adjustment and White Balance layers to do a final colour grade.

One Final Note & Next Steps

Light painting is a skill every automotive photographer should learn. It gives you control, sets your work apart and allows you to create images most photographers can't do.

When you understand how to shape light, you stop relying on conditions and start deciding how the car looks. That level of control is valuable. It is something clients notice and are willing to pay for.

Thank you for taking the time to read this guide. Now go put it to use!

- *Mitch Hemming*

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